



“More Indians settled overseas becoming affluent, plus technology, led to more people accessing the game”

HARSHA BHOGLE

CRICKET
COMMENTATOR



208 |

Venu Pisike, Chairman of the Board of Directors at USA Cricket, the body that promotes cricket at all levels in the country, feels the T20 World Cup, held last year in the West Indies and US, was a breakthrough. “The big moment was the T20 India-Pakistan match (held in the US), and a lot of people got excited about it,” he says with a grin.

GLOBAL SPORT?

Cricket’s rise on the global stage has been evident for over two decades. A significant turning point came in the mid-1990s, with financial deals such as Sachin Tendulkar’s ₹45-crore five-year pact with World Tel and the 1996 World Cup held in the subcontinent. The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) solidified its position as a powerful governing body,

popularising the sport not only in India, but also among the Indian diaspora. “The big reason for cricket reaching out to a larger global audience is predominantly to do with the Indian diaspora. More Indians settled overseas becoming affluent, plus technology, led to more people accessing the game,” Harsha Bhogle, a renowned commentator, explains. “If cricket was an English game played in India, it is now an Indian game, and the diaspora easily carry their love for it.” Immigrant populations have played a crucial role in spreading cricket beyond South Asia. In Europe, cricket’s popularity has surged, with many countries embracing the sport. “This demographic shift has contributed to the rapid growth of cricket in Europe, making it the largest growing sport in the

region,” says Roger Feiner, CEO of the European Cricket League, which hosts 10-over matches across clubs in Europe.

The Indian Premier League (IPL), which debuted in 2008, popularised the shorter T20 format. It is often hailed as the biggest innovation in cricket since the turn of the century. “The moment a sport starts to get entertaining, it will go mass. A lot of credit must be given to the IPL since it showed that a robust business model can be created through entertainment,” says Ajimon Francis, MD of Brand Finance India, an international brand valuation firm, says.

THE SHORTER FORMATS

The appeal of shorter formats isn’t limited to India. Leagues like the Abu Dhabi T10, the Caribbean